

Provenance Authority Drift Observation - Pending Record

Purpose

This is a lean, temporary record of a provenance concern that emerged during the current conversation. It is intentionally marked **PENDING**. It is not a finished theory, accusation, or technical diagnosis. Its purpose is to preserve the observation and the proposed test so it can be incorporated into the author's canonical record later without relying on memory.

Observation

The author reports repeated instances in which later AI summaries, reconstructions, or remembered context appear to change the apparent origin of ideas. In some cases, concepts the author remembers introducing are later presented in a way that makes them appear model-originated, jointly originated, or origin-ambiguous.

The author also supplied a screenshot showing a prior ChatGPT notification referring to generated Markdown and PDF artifacts that are no longer accessible where the author expected them to be. The screenshot establishes that the system previously represented those artifacts as having existed. It does not, by itself, establish why they later became inaccessible.

Current evidentiary position

OBSERVED: A historical system notification represented specific generated artifacts as complete and available.

OBSERVED: The author currently reports that some expected historical artifacts or message-thread representations are no longer accessible in the same way.

OBSERVED: The author reports that later AI reconstructions have, in some instances, appeared to alter or obscure idea origin and authorship.

INFERENCE: There may be a provenance-integrity problem in which later system representations are not sufficiently anchored to the original event-level source record.

UNRESOLVED: Whether the cause is conversational compaction, memory synthesis, retrieval selection, UI persistence, file retention, model reconstruction, or another mechanism.

NOT ESTABLISHED: Deliberate rewriting, theft, intentional misattribution, or any specific platform mechanism.

Testable claim

A defensible claim for later investigation is:

Under some conditions, later AI reconstructions may alter, omit, or obscure the recorded origin of ideas or artifacts relative to the earliest surviving source record.

This can be tested without inferring motive.

Proposed audit method

For each selected idea or artifact:

1. Locate the earliest surviving occurrence.
2. Preserve the surrounding source context showing who introduced it.
3. Record timestamp, source, file or message identifier, and any available metadata.
4. Locate later summaries, memories, handoffs, or reconstructions referring to the same item.
5. Compare the later representation against the earliest source.
6. Classify origin as `USER`, `MODEL`, `JOINT`, `EXTERNAL`, or `UNKNOWN` at each stage.
7. Record whether origin was preserved, omitted, made ambiguous, or changed.
8. Keep visible-transcript changes separate from memory/synthesis/retrieval changes.
9. Preserve contradictory evidence rather than forcing a conclusion.
10. Only promote a causal explanation when the evidence distinguishes it from alternatives.

Administrative rule derived from the observation

Authorship and provenance must be stored as explicit structural fields rather than inferred from polished wording or later summaries. Once origin is established from the earliest reliable source, later representations must not silently overwrite it.

A suitable minimal event record is:

- event identifier
- timestamp
- source identifier
- origin: `USER | MODEL | JOINT | EXTERNAL | UNKNOWN`
- original text or source pointer
- transformation type
- parent/source event identifier
- version
- integrity hash where useful
- confidence or unresolved status

Current state

This issue is **captured but not investigated to completion**. No external canonical document has been changed. No Google Drive or Google Docs record has been touched. The record is deliberately lean so it can be inserted into the author's own provenance system later.

Next valid action

When the author has time, select one high-value example with both an early source record and a later reconstruction. Perform a side-by-side provenance comparison before expanding the hypothesis.

Until then, preserve this record as a pending observation rather than continuing the investigation.